for related offences as well as mechanisms for their investigation, prosecution, trial and international cooperation' (p. 745). This act has been criticized for giving unlimited powers to 'authorized personnel' who may confiscate data and 'information systems' under the guise of ensuring law and order, and security of the Pakistani public, while also threatening 'free speech' (Freedom House 2016; Digital Rights Foundation 2015; Human Rights Watch 2017). A report by the Jinnah Institute that examined PECA against similar laws in India, the United Arab Emirates and the United States concluded that this legislation 'has the highest number of crimes included under law, specifies harsher penalties and awards unrestricted authority to investigate and prosecute' compared to the other three countries in their study (Kamal 2017, p. 9). Citizens are further vulnerable as 'ISPs [internet service providers] and mobile companies are not obliged to maintain or comply with data protection policies that protect consumers', thereby allowing the government easy access to citizen data online (Freedom House 2017, p. 15).

However, such draconian legislation is not new to Pakistan. 'The 1996 Pakistan Telecommunications Act already' supported 'censorship for the protection of national security' primarily for 'religious reasons'. In fact, 'Section 99 of the penal code' allowed 'the government to restrict information that might be prejudicial to the national interest, to justify filtering antimilitary, blasphemous or antistate content' (Freedom House 2016). According to a report by the Citizen Lab at the University of Toronto, Pakistan had been using 'Netsweeper technology' to block not just 'blasphemous and anti-Islamic content' but also 'sites promoting Balochi, Sindhi, and Pashtun human rights and political autonomy in Pakistan' (Citizen Lab 2013, p. 2; also see Yusaf 2015). Furthermore, in order to control the 'national narrative', as highlighted by Yusaf (2015), 'websites of religious minorities' have also been banned in the past. Examples include websites or blogs launched by the Shia and Ahmadiyya communities 'to document instances of sectarian violence and campaign for their rights', two of which were 'temporarily blocked' by the government in July 2012 (Yusaf 2015, p. 170).

The threat of terrorism, and the use of mobile phones as detonators, has also resulted in greater control of mobile services. Such control increased inequalities in access across Pakistan; for example, in Balochistan 'in late 2016 and early 2017, mobile internet was suspended in the province for undefined security reasons', and in the FATA 'mobile internet service was shut down for more than a year' beginning in June 2016 (Freedom House 2016, pp. 1, 3). The Freedom House (2016) report highlights greater surveillance of citizens in Pakistan through the